



The impact of couples' conflicts on everyday sadists' relationship satisfaction

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ABSTRACT

Introduction: Everyday sadism, defined as an individual who obtains pleasure through hurting others verbally, physically, or vicariously, is emerging as an important construct in psychopathology research, with researchers trying to understand specific behaviors (i.e., low agreeableness, callousness, and aggression) of individuals with sadistic tendencies, particularly in regard to relationships. The current study explored the associations between everyday sadism and couples' conflicts within their relationship and examined whether conflict level mediated the relations between sadistic traits and relationship satisfaction. More specifically, we hypothesized higher sadistic tendencies and more conflict to predict an increase in relationship satisfaction.

Methods: Participants were 163 individuals recruited from the online web-source Mechanical Amazon Turk (MTurk) (57.1 % men, *M*_{age} = 32.83). They completed surveys on sadistic tendencies, the amount of conflicts within their romantic relationship, and their relationship satisfaction.

Results: Results indicated that everyday sadism has a negative relationship with sadistic individuals' relationship satisfaction. Multiple mediation models demonstrated that overall sadism is indirectly related to relationship satisfaction via the effect of couples' conflict. Additionally, couples' conflicts partially mediated the relationship between verbal sadistic tendencies, had no mediated effect on physical sadistic tendencies, and was fully mediated by vicarious sadistic tendencies and relationship satisfaction.

Discussion: Findings provide insight into how everyday sadist's behaviors and relationship conflict affect relationship satisfaction. Specifically, the interrelations of relationship conflicts and an individual's subtype(s) of sadistic tendencies (i.e. overall, verbal, and vicarious sadism) account for the underlying connection between these personality traits and individuals with sadistic tendencies' way of finding satisfaction within their relationships.

1. Introduction

Healthy romantic relationships are important for increasing health and well-being (Gómez-López et al., 2019), and romantic partners are typically motivated to maintain the quality of their relationship as much as possible (Davis & Oathout, 1987). However, certain personality traits may inhibit an individual's ability to sustain healthy intimate relationships. Of increased concern is intimate partner violence (IPV), which includes but is not limited to physical, sexual, and psychological abuse (Brewer et al., 2018). Although most research has focused on the experiences of victims and perpetrators of IPV surrounding physical and sexual abuse (Brewer et al., 2018), personality researchers have recently turned their attention to psychological abuse. Everyday sadism,

characterized by experiencing enjoyment from observing both the psychological and physical suffering of others (Tsoukas & March, 2018), is emerging as an important construct within this area.

The hallmarks of everyday sadism include enjoyment of inflicting physical or psychological pain (e.g., by physical or verbal assaults), observing others' suffering, asserting dominance (Book et al., 2016; Pfattheicher & Schindler, 2015), suggesting callousness, and antagonistic attitudes (i.e., low agreeableness; Thomas & Egan, 2022; Meere & Egan, 2017; Book et al., 2016; Paulhus, 2014). Suffering is often significantly rewarding and characterized in three ways: inflicting suffering verbally (e.g., humiliating or making fun of someone) or physically (e.g., physically harming someone), as well as experiencing it vicariously (e.g., watching violent shows or games). These experiences

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are rewarding, even at a personal cost (Pfattheicher & Schindler, 2015). Considering the deficiency in the affect and antagonistic behavior style in sadism and related constructs (e.g., psychopathy, narcissism, and Machiavellianism; Thomas & Egan, 2022; Meere & Egan, 2017; Book et al., 2016; Paulhus, 2014), it is unsurprising that these personality styles are associated with poor intimate relationship quality and satisfaction (Ali & Chamorro-Premuzic, 2010). Therefore, we suggest that everyday sadism should also be explored within the context of relationship conflict and satisfaction in addition to low agreeableness, callousness, and aggression, as these three characteristics are core behaviors of those with sadistic tendencies (Meere & Egan, 2017; Paulhus, 2014; Thomas & Egan, 2022).

1.1. Low agreeableness

To expand, agreeable individuals get along with people and are seen as friendly, considerate of other's feelings, and willing to compromise their interests for others (McCullough, 2001). Disagreeable individuals are low in such qualities and are commonly known to be uninterested in others' well-being (McCullough, 2001). Thus, higher agreeableness may be an essential component for achieving high relationship satisfaction (Malouff et al., 2010). When couples can comfortably voice their opinions and talk through any concerns, the chances of both persons experiencing a healthy and happy relationship are high (McCullough, 2001).

Individuals with sadistic tendencies tend to lack the ability to agree and compromise. Frequent occurrence of such behaviors in relationships may lead to decreased relationship satisfaction for couples (Malouff et al., 2010). Interestingly, however, relationship satisfaction has not been explored from the perspective of individuals with sadistic tendencies; rather, previous studies have mostly focused on the partners' sense of relationship quality. Those individuals may respond differently to such interactions compared to their partners. By avoiding conflict resolution with their significant others, they may create opportunities to observe their partner's emotional turmoil. As individuals with sadistic traits derive pleasure through others' suffering (Buckels et al., 2013), this study hypothesized that such negative interactions may possibly raise their relationship satisfaction.

1.2. Callousness

Davis and Oathout (1987) identified empathy as an important characteristic influencing the maintenance of relationships and defined it as one person's responsive actions towards another individual's experiences. How an individual responds to others, both cognitively and emotionally, will play a significant role in improving or weakening one's relationship. As stated by Ullrich et al. (2008), "lack of remorse and callousness are counterproductive for successful intimate relationships" (p. 1169). Callousness, otherwise known as lack of empathy, is another common trait found in sadistic individuals (Book et al., 2016). Additionally, individuals with greater sadistic traits may also display greater callousness (Book et al., 2016).

Due to limitations in research on everyday sadism, there is little knowledge regarding its empathic qualities. Although evidence suggests that individuals with sadistic tendencies lack empathy (Thomas & Egan, 2022), some argue they possess intact cognitive empathy, enabling them to successfully harm others (O'Meara et al., 2011). While Buckels et al. (2013) discovered that sadism negatively correlated with perspective-taking and empathic concern, others found that they do not differ significantly from those with low levels of sadism in their ability to comprehend the emotions of others (O'Meara et al., 2011). More recently, a study reported sadism was negatively associated with affective empathy and social skills, whereas the relationship with cognitive empathy was not significant (Sest & March, 2017). Therefore, they might not have any response to their significant others for their suffering, thus, giving their partners the impression that they don't care for their well-being. This finding is in agreement with the concept of

emotional shallowness and coldness that is related to callousness (Mededović & Petrović, 2015). They may come off as emotionally disengaging themselves from the relationship. Heightened relationship disengagement is associated with reduced relationship satisfaction (Barry et al., 2008). From a sadist's perspective, however, they might not see such callous/disengaging behaviors as an issue, and research investigating this is also lacking. Additionally, they may not care about their partner's feelings or emotions (Blötner & Mokros, 2023). Moreover, we hypothesize that lacking empathy could create arguments and conflicts within a relationship, which for an individual with sadistic tendencies, could raise their relationship satisfaction.

1.3. Aggressiveness

Aggression in an intimate relationship could lead to relationship dissatisfaction. When couples have a healthy bond, they can sense their partner's anger, voice their feelings, discuss what triggered them, and find a solution to their issue (Davis & Oathout, 1987). However, if anger and aggression are not properly handled, the conflict can take a turn for the worse. Two studies have found associations between everyday sadism and unprovoked aggression (Buckels et al., 2013), which is defined as aimlessly intensified aggression without justifiable reasons. Given the core characteristics of individuals with sadistic tendencies, exhibiting dominance towards their significant others with their aggressiveness may allow them to report a greater relationship satisfaction. In sum, this is giving them another way to get pleasure out of their significant other's suffering (Zeigler-Hill et al., 2016). It is thought they may use their personality characteristics to their advantage by creating conflicts within their intimate relationships to obtain pleasure and derive higher relationship satisfaction from getting their way.

Therefore, the aim of this study is to explore how sadistic traits, as characterized by low agreeableness, callousness, and aggression, are associated with overall relationship satisfaction based on the number of conflicts with their significant other, a perspective which has not been previously explored. Given the previous focus on the victims of other's sadistic tendencies, the present study provides unique insight into the perspective of a population rarely included in personality research. By examining the perspective of individuals with sadistic traits (i.e., non-clinical and non-forensic individuals who are still productive members of society), this study may offer additional explanations behind the transition from everyday sadism to that of clinical and forensic populations.

1.4. Current study

The current study proposed hypothetical models of the mediating role of conflicts in the relationship between sadistic tendencies and relationship satisfaction. Individuals with sadistic tendencies may experience conflicts in their daily lives to obtain pleasure as already described above (Buckels et al., 2013; Zeigler-Hill et al., 2016). However, with conflicts being a possible source of pleasure, it may predispose an individual to engage in a conflict with someone close to them, such as a romantic partner increasing their relationship satisfaction. Thus, we proposed four mediational models: 1) couples' conflicts mediating the relationship between overall sadism and relationship satisfaction, 2) couples' conflicts mediating the relationship between verbal sadism and relationship satisfaction, 3) couples' conflicts mediating the relationship between physical sadism and relationship satisfaction, and 4) couples' conflicts mediating the relationship between vicarious sadism and relationship satisfaction.

2. Methods

2.1. Procedure and participants

The current study was approved by the [redacted] Institutional

Review Board. Participants were recruited via Amazon Mechanical Turk (MTurk). To be eligible for the study, participants provided electronic consent, and met the following inclusion criteria: 18 years old or older, ability to read and write fluently in English, and had been in a current or previous romantic relationship lasting 6 months or longer in the past year. Eligible and consenting participants completed a self-report survey on Qualtrics assessing sociodemographic characteristics, sadistic tendencies, conflicts, and relationship satisfaction. The survey included three validity checks to ensure attention and comprehension (Thomas & Clifford, 2017). Participants who completed the entire survey and met three validity checks received a digital gift card worth \$1.30.

We obtained responses from 229 participants, excluded 66 participants because (1) they reported never being in a romantic relationship lasting at least 6 months or longer in the past year, (2) they provided invalid data (i.e., they did not pass the validity checks), or (3) they had incomplete surveys (e.g., only reported age). The final sample included 163 individuals, averaging 32.83 years of age (57.1 % men). Detailed demographic information is in Table 2.

2.2. Measures

2.2.1. Sadistic tendencies

The Comprehensive Assessment of Sadistic Tendencies (CAST; Buckels & Paulhus, 2013) is a 18-item self-report measure assessing various sadistic tendencies (e.g., direct-verbal sadism, direct-physical sadism, and vicarious sadism). Eleven optional filler items can be used at the researcher's discretion to offset the negativity of the assessment. For this study, 4 filler items (i.e., additional items to offset the negativity of the measure's original items; "I'm considered to be a kind person.") were chosen based on their item content and how it relates to the sadistic individual's behaviors and thoughts towards others (e.g., significant others). Participants rate each item using 7-point Likert scale (1 = strongly disagree, 7 = strongly agree). Higher scores on the CAST indicated higher levels of sadism. The CAST has been demonstrated to have both good convergent and discriminant validity (Buckels et al., 2013). In the current study, Cronbach's α was 0.92 for overall score, 0.89 for verbal sadism scale, and 0.88 for the physical and vicarious sadism scales.

2.2.2. Number of conflicts

The Revised Conflict Tactics Scale (CTS2; Straus et al., 1996) is a 78-item measure assessing differences of disagreements within a relationship. For this study, we excluded the items on the partners' point of view due to not having the partner participate in the study, and only used the 39-items focusing on the participant's point of view. It has five different subscales: four aggression-related subscales (e.g., psychological, physical, sexual, and injury from aggression) and one negotiation subscale (e.g., "I showed respect for my partner's feelings about an issue"). The CTS2 has seven response options: never, once, twice, 3–5 times, 6–10 times, 11–20 times, and >20 times. Higher scores indicated high levels of conflict. The CTS2 improved upon the psychometric properties of the original CTS, and has been demonstrated to have good construct validity as well as improved content validity and reliability (Straus et al., 1996). We used the total CTS2 score as an index of overall conflict in a relationship. In the current study, Cronbach's α was 0.94 for the total scale score.

2.2.3. Relationship satisfaction

The Relationship Assessment Scale (RAS; Vaughn & Matyastik Baier, 1999) is a 7-item self-report measure of global relationship satisfaction. Participants rated items using 1–5 Likert-type scale (1 = not satisfied, 5 = very satisfied). A total score is calculated by averaging all item responses. Higher total scores represent higher levels of relationship satisfaction. RAS scores have good construct, criterion-related, and predictive validity (Vaughn & Matyastik Baier, 1999). In the current study, Cronbach's α was 0.86 for the total scale score.

2.3. Statistical analysis

Based on benchmarks of skewness > 2 and kurtosis > 7 (Curran et al., 1996), all total scores were normally distributed. All data analyses were conducted via SPSS statistics version 29 utilizing PROCESS SPSS macro procedures (Model 1; Hayes, 2012). We analyzed four mediation models: the relationships between 1) overall sadism and relationship satisfaction, mediated by conflicts, 2) verbal sadism and relationship satisfaction, mediated by conflicts, 3) physical sadism and relationship satisfaction, mediated by conflicts, and 4) vicarious sadism and relationship satisfaction, mediated by conflicts. The approach to mediation analyses is the product of path coefficients approach estimating the indirect effect's standard error with the multivariate delta method through bootstrapping 10,000 samples (MacKinnon & Luecken, 2008).

Our sample ($n = 163$) was adequate according to the a-priori power analyses conducted with G*Power 3.1 (Faul et al., 2007). We determined a sample of 55 individuals would be needed to detect a medium effect size (0.15; Cohen, 1988) with 0.80 power and at an alpha set to 0.05 for a mediation regression analyses with one mediator for all 4 models. Assumptions of mediation regression analyses and zero-order correlations were examined among the primary variables.

3. Results

3.1. Descriptives of measures and demographics

The measure's specific details such as means, standard deviations, and confidence intervals are reported in Table 1. The 163 participants had a mean age of 32.83 ($SD = 8.60$, range = 18–60), and 58.3 % identified as White/Caucasian, 28.2 % Asian, 7.4 % Hispanic/Latino, 4.9 % African American, and 1.2 % as other. For relationship status, 47.5 % reported being married, 26.5 % were engaged/committed, 17.9 % were single but dating, 6.2 % were single and currently not dating, 1.2 % were divorced/separated and 0.6 % as other (Table 2).

3.2. Mediation models

3.2.1. Overall sadism

We tested whether couples' conflicts and relationship satisfaction occurred via the effects of overall sadistic tendencies. The full model significantly predicted relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.17$, $F(1,151) = 29.88$, $p < 0.001$; Fig. 1). After controlling for shared variance, overall sadism remained statistically significantly related to relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.20$, $F(2,150) = 18.42$, $p < 0.05$). Couples' conflicts were indirectly related to relationship satisfaction via overall sadism, $b = -0.219$, $SE = 0.040$, 95 % CI: $[-0.298, -0.140]$.

3.2.2. Verbal sadism

We tested whether couples' conflicts and relationship satisfaction occurred via the effects of verbal sadistic tendencies. The full model significantly predicted relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.129$, $F(1,151) = 22.39$, $p < 0.001$; Fig. 2). After controlling for shared variance, verbal sadism remained statistically significantly related to relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.191$, $F(2,150) = 17.66$, $p < 0.001$). Couples' conflicts

Table 1
Descriptive statistics and reliabilities of the measures.

	M	SD	Confidence intervals
CAST	61.72	25.01	57.86–65.59
Verbal CAST	18.21	9.54	16.74–19.69
Physical CAST	11.22	8.48	9.91–12.53
Vicarious CAST	21.03	10.34	19.43–22.63
CTS-2	184.64	35.72	179.12–190.17
RAS	28.72	5.23	27.92–29.53

Note. $N = 163$. CAST = Comprehensive Assessment of Sadistic Tendencies, CTS-2 = Revised Conflict Tactics Scale, RAS = Relationship Assessment Scale.

Table 2
Information on demographics ($N = 163$).

Variables	<i>M</i> (<i>SD</i>)	<i>n</i> (%)
Age	32.83 (8.60)	
Gender		
Male		93 (57.1 %)
Female		70 (42.9 %)
Racial background		
White/Caucasian		95 (58.3 %)
Asian		46 (28.2 %)
Hispanic/Latino		12 (7.4 %)
African American		8 (4.9 %)
Other		2 (1.2 %)
Relationship status		
Married		77 (47.5 %)
Engaged/committed		43 (26.5 %)
Were single but dating		29 (17.9 %)
Single and currently not dating		10 (6.2 %)
Divorced/separated		2 (1.2 %)
Other		1 (0.6 %)

Note. Rounding to two decimal places contributed to percentage totals not equaling 100 %.

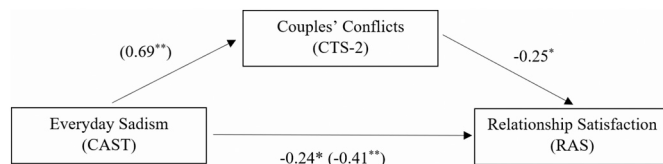


Fig. 1. Standardized regression coefficients for the relationship between everyday sadism and relationship satisfaction as mediated by couples' conflicts. The standardized regression coefficient between everyday sadism and relationship satisfaction, before controlling for couples' conflicts, is in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$.

** $p < 0.001$.

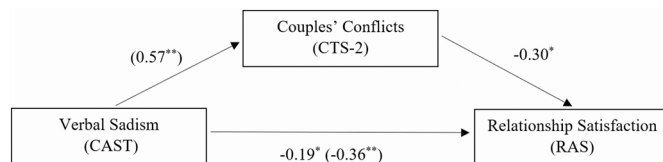


Fig. 2. Standardized regression coefficients for the relationship between verbal sadism and relationship satisfaction as mediated by couples' conflicts. The standardized regression coefficient between verbal sadism and relationship satisfaction, before controlling for couples' conflicts, is in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$.

** $p < 0.001$.

were indirectly related to relationship satisfaction via verbal sadism, $b = -0.091$, $SE = 0.043$, 95 % CI: $[-0.177, -0.005]$.

3.2.3. Physical sadism

We tested whether couples' conflicts and relationship satisfaction occurred via the effects of physical sadistic tendencies. The full model significantly predicted relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.129$, $F(1,151) = 22.39$, $p < 0.001$; Fig. 3). After controlling for shared variance, physical sadism remained statistically significantly related to relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.195$, $F(2,150) = 18.20$, $p < 0.001$). Couples' conflicts were indirectly related to relationship satisfaction via physical sadism, $b = -0.117$, $SE = 0.051$, 95 % CI: $[-0.218, -0.016]$.

3.2.4. Vicarious sadism

We tested whether couples' conflicts and relationship satisfaction occurred via the effects of vicarious sadistic tendencies. The full model significantly predicted relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.112$, $F(1,151)$

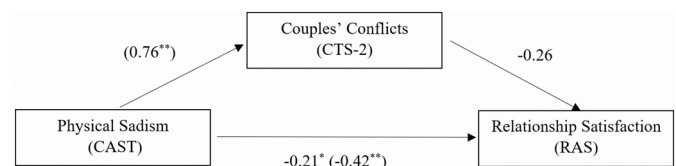


Fig. 3. Standardized regression coefficients for the relationship between physical sadism and relationship satisfaction as mediated by couples' conflicts. The standardized regression coefficient between physical sadism and relationship satisfaction, before controlling for couples' conflicts, is in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$.

** $p < 0.001$.

$= 19.084$, $p < 0.001$; Fig. 4). After controlling for shared variance, vicarious sadism remained statistically significantly related to relationship satisfaction, ($R^2 = 0.184$, $F(2,150) = 16.91$, $p < 0.001$). Couples' conflicts were indirectly related to relationship satisfaction via vicarious sadism, $b = -0.081$, $SE = 0.046$, 95 % CI: $[-0.172, -0.010]$.

4. Discussion

The current study aimed to investigate the extent to which the amount of couples' conflicts mediates the relationship between everyday sadism and relationship satisfaction. Specifically, it was hypothesized that individuals with high amounts of sadistic traits would perceive a lower relationship satisfaction. It was also proposed that the amount of conflict couples endure within their relationship would mediate these associations. That is, more conflict would lead to higher relationship satisfaction in sadistic individuals. The results, however, revealed that only a portion of these assertions were supported.

A negative association was found between the level of sadistic traits an individual may have and their relationship satisfaction. No current research has been able to provide this information from the perspective of individuals with sadistic traits. This finding makes sense considering research on their potential dating patterns. For example, psychopathy and narcissism, traits commonly associated with sadism, were positively associated with an exploitative, short-term dating style, typically consisting of one-night stands (Jonason et al., 2012). These traits also correlate with low agreeableness (Paulhus & Williams, 2002), which is associated with both IPV in long-term relationships and relationship dissatisfaction (Shen & Lan, 2023). However, participants in long-term, significant relationships may be unable to act upon their desire to engage in sadistic behaviors. This could lead to personal frustration, a lack of fulfillment, and guilt or shame regarding these desires, which could each result in lower relationship satisfaction (Chester et al., 2019).

Our study proposed that those showing a greater degree of sadistic tendencies will report a high level of relationship satisfaction via a high amount of conflicts in the intimate relationship, and such individuals will report low relationship satisfaction when having a low amount of conflicts with their significant others, was partially supported. That is, although mediational effects emerged, the associations were in the opposite direction from what the study predicted. Those with higher

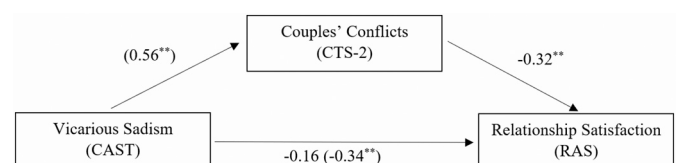


Fig. 4. Standardized regression coefficients for the relationship between vicarious sadism and relationship satisfaction as mediated by couples' conflicts. The standardized regression coefficient between vicarious sadism and relationship satisfaction, before controlling for couples' conflicts, is in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$.

** $p < 0.001$.

amount of sadistic traits reported higher amounts of conflicts within their relationship and lower relationship satisfaction. Therefore, relationship conflicts may not be the main source of pleasure/satisfaction for individuals with greater sadistic traits.

Alternatively, individuals with low levels of sadistic traits reported fewer conflicts and higher relationship satisfaction. Individuals with little to no sadistic traits typically have healthier relationships due to not possessing low agreeableness, callousness, aggressiveness (Malouff et al., 2010; Mededović & Petrović, 2015), which can be destructive and create conflicts within any relationship (Malouff et al., 2010; Ullrich et al., 2008). People high in agreeableness often resolve conflicted situations whereas individuals high in disagreeableness have issues with resolving conflicts (McCullough, 2001). Individuals high in agreeableness will often act as the mediator or peacemaker in an argument, attempting to appease themselves and the other individual, however, those low in agreeableness do not (McCullough, 2001).

Individuals with a higher sadistic traits often lack empathy (Book et al., 2016), the ability to read and understand people and be in-tune with, or resonate with, other individuals. Because conflicts are detected by sensing one's partner's emotions, they may not be able to understand and care how their significant other is feeling, which could result in a conflict. The reasons for this are multifaceted. Sadists derive pleasure from others' suffering, which applies across varying situations. First, sadists are motivated to hurt others and can harm others to obtain a sense of power or control. Additionally, individuals specifically experiencing sexual pleasure resultant from inflicting pain may be motivated to cause harm as well. Participants in long-term, significant relationships may be less likely to act upon their desire to engage in sadistic behaviors due to consistent increases in negative affect following inflicting harm (Chester et al., 2019). This could lead to personal frustration, a lack of fulfillment, and possibly guilt or shame regarding these desires (Chester et al., 2019), which could each result lower relationship satisfaction. Sadistic individuals may come off as emotionally disengaged from the relationship. Previous literature has found a direct, negative correlation between relationship disengagement and relationship satisfaction in healthy couples (Barry et al., 2008).

Conflict is known to create stress within a relationship (Neff & Karney, 2009). Neff and Karney (2009) found that couples experiencing more stress within their relationship reported feeling less comfortable and confident about the relationship. Since individuals with sadistic tendencies' common core characteristics are positively correlate with creation of conflicts within a relationship, stress from the conflicts could affect their overall relationship satisfaction.

Additional analyses uncovered varying results for the three facets of everyday sadism (i.e., verbal sadism, physical sadism, and vicarious sadism). First, verbal sadism was partially mediated by the frequency of conflicts within a relationship. Individuals with higher verbal sadistic traits reported high amounts of conflict, leading to low relationship satisfaction, but also had direct relations with relationship satisfaction (Fig. 2). On the other hand, physical sadism was not mediated by the frequency of conflicts within a relationship but had only a direct association with relationship satisfaction (Fig. 3). Furthermore, vicarious sadism was fully mediated by the frequency of conflicts within a relationship with no meaningful direct path to relationship satisfaction (Fig. 4). Individuals with higher vicariously sadistic traits reported having more conflicts within their relationship, leading to lower relationship satisfaction. Thus, vicarious sadism may be the least severe form of sadism since it does not have a direct effect on negative relationship satisfaction but only via high amounts of conflicts within a relationship. Comparatively, physical sadism is more severe and may directly cause poor relationship quality and satisfaction regardless of relationship conflict levels. Additionally, we did not control other personality facets such as psychopathy, narcissism, and Machiavellianism, which future studies should do to confirm that their results are due to an individual's sadistic tendencies. Lastly, we did not collect data on how

long the participants had been in their relationship. Future studies should analyze the impact of relationship duration within this sample.

Despite these limitations, we note some strengths of this study. First, no study to date has looked at how sadistic tendencies can affect relationship satisfaction from the individual with sadistic tendencies' point of view. This study showed increased conflicts were not the main source of relationship pleasure, which should be further investigated in the future. Secondly, these findings have clinical and forensic implications, providing insight into the detrimental conflicts everyday sadist may incite within their relationship. Treatment providers should assess for sadistic tendencies to understand how these behaviors can influence their interaction with others. Moreover, it may be helpful for remedial and early preventive interventions to target components that can reduce sadistic tendencies and urges as well as any factors possibly strengthening their relations. Specifically, findings can be used to inform treatment programs of the impact of personality differences on IPV perpetration, and to tailor these interventions based on identification of traits or other factors contributing most to perpetration and recidivism. From a forensic lens, targeting these components may also help to prevent instances of offending (i.e., IPV; Plouffe et al., 2020). Given the potential relationship between these behaviors and the criminal justice system, clinical and forensic researchers should collaborate on interventions to address mental health symptoms and reduce the possibility of future delinquent behaviors. Finally, these results may be important for educating survivors of IPV on the role of personality variables in relationship conflicts. Individuals should be informed of potential 'red flags' associated with maladaptive personality characteristics, and for family members, friends, and healthcare providers to support survivors in safely ending relationships with individuals exhibiting higher sadistic tendencies.

5. Conclusion

In conclusion, the current study adds to the literature on the interrelations among sadistic tendencies, couples' conflicts, and relationship satisfaction. Our findings suggest that overall, verbal, and vicarious sadistic tendencies are at least partially related to relationship satisfaction among everyday sadists. Given the paucity of research from the sadist's perspective in this area, these findings provide novel insights into the lesser degree to which an individual's type(s) of sadistic tendencies account for the underlying relationship between their way of finding satisfaction within their relationship, an area in need of further research.

Ethical statement

This study was approved by the Southern Illinois University Edwardsville's Institutional Review Board.

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Software: Andrea Fentem

Supervision: N/A

Validation: Andrea Fentem

Visualization: Andrea Fentem

Roles/Writing - original draft: Andrea Fentem & Faith Stoneking

Writing - review & editing: Andrea Fentem & Faith Stoneking

Declaration of competing interest

None.

Data availability

Data will be made available on request.

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